Current Psychology (2026) 45:1045
https://doi.org/10.1007/s12144-026-09601-9

Does self-disclosure gain more "fans"? the relationship between leader self-disclosure on social networking sites and employee followership behavior

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Received: 12 May 2025 / Accepted: 28 May 2026 / Published online: 5 June 2026
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Abstract
In spite of the significant scholarly interest in the traditional dyadic interaction between leaders and employees, limited attention has been paid to how and when leaders' online social networking activities influence employee behavior. We developed a theoretical framework drawing on the theories of dispositional attribution, aimed at exploring the mechanism between leaders' self-disclosure on social networking sites (SNSs) and employee followership behavior. Based on an analysis of two-wave data from 281 full-time employees, the results indicated that leaders' work-related self-disclosure on SNSs was positively related to agentic characteristics perceptions, and leaders' non-work-related self-disclosures on SNSs positively predicted communal characteristic perceptions, which in turn were positively associated with followership behavior. Moreover, these indirect relationships were attenuated by impression management attribution. This research contributes to the theoretical understanding of leaders' self-disclosure on SNSs and provides practical implications regarding how leaders' online presence may be associated with followership dynamics.

Keywords Leaders' self-disclosure on social networking sites · Agentic characteristics · Communal characteristics · Impression management attribution · Followership behavior

Introduction

In the digital era, social networking sites (SNSs) have become ubiquitous platforms for communication and interaction, transcending traditional boundaries of time and space. Defined as web-based services that allow individuals to construct a public or semi-public profile, share information, and connect with others, SNSs platforms like LinkedIn, Facebook, Tik Tok, and WeChat have transformed the way we interact and present ourselves to the world (Boyd & Ellison, 2007; Balcerowska & Brailovskaia, 2024). In SNSs, individuals disclose themselves by posting/updating news, uploading photos, and posting logs/comments (Subrahmanyam et al., 2008). The emergence of self-disclosure on SNSs has become a pivotal area of inquiry within the intersection of computer-mediated communication, business, and organizational behavior (Oghazi et al., 2020; Osatuyi et al., 2018; Yang et al., 2023). Self-disclosure refers to the act of individuals voluntarily and intentionally sharing information about themselves with others (Posey et al., 2010; Yang et al., 2026). In the realm of leadership, the disclosure of information by leaders on SNSs is increasingly significant, as these digital footprints can profoundly influence interpersonal trust, liking, and the development of task-oriented relationships (Heavey et al., 2020; Gibson et al., 2018; Rothbard et al., 2022).

A growing body of research has begun to explore the implications of leaders' online behavior for workplace

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outcomes (e.g., Heavey et al., 2020; Rothbard et al., 2022). Yet self-disclosure on SNSs differs from its traditional face-to-face counterpart in important ways: SNS-based disclosures are typically directed at a broader and more diverse audience, persist over time as digital records, and lack the nonverbal cues that facilitate interpretation in face-to-face interactions (Bazarova & Choi, 2014; Knop et al., 2016). These distinctive features suggest that the dynamics and consequences of leaders' self-disclosure on SNSs may not be fully captured by existing models grounded in offline contexts, rendering it a phenomenon worthy of dedicated scholarly attention. Despite this, the leadership literature has yet to adequately account for the unique nature of SNS-based disclosure; in particular, relatively limited attention has been paid to how the specific content of leaders' disclosures on SNS, especially the distinction between disclosures that relate to work and those that are of a personal nature. This is a consequential omission, because leaders' sharing of information with employees is essential to organizational functioning (Katz & Kahn, 1978), and work-related and non-work disclosures are conceptually different (Nifadkar et al., 2019), likely eliciting distinct employee perceptions and behavioral responses that remain insufficiently understood.

Drawing on theories of dispositional attribution (Jones & Davis, 1965; Trope, 1986) and the agency-communion framework (Abele & Wojciszke, 2007; Fiske et al., 2007), the present study addresses these gaps by developing and testing a moderated mediation model that links leaders' work-related and non-work-related self-disclosures on SNSs to followership behavior through distinct perceptual pathways. Dispositional attribution theory suggests that observers interpret the behaviors they witness as cues from which to infer the enduring characteristics of actors (Jones & Davis, 1965). Integrating this logic with the agency-communion framework, which distinguishes agency, rooted in assessments of competence and self-proficiency, from communion, rooted in assessments of warmth and other-orientation (Abele & Wojciszke, 2014), we propose that work-related self-disclosure is positively associated with perceptions of agentic characteristics, whereas non-work-related self-disclosure is positively associated with perceptions of communal characteristics, and that both types of perceptions in turn positively predict employee followership behavior. We selected followership behavior as the outcome because it directly captures employees' dispositional inferences toward their leaders based on observed online disclosures (Lord et al., 2020), and it encompasses not merely task compliance but a range of behaviors reflecting employees' willingness to actively support and engage with their leaders, making it a fitting outcome for both agentic and communal attributions.

Furthermore, theories of dispositional attribution suggested that when an individual identifies plausible boundary conditions for an observed behavior, the likelihood of attributing behavior to the actor's dispositions is diminished (Reeder & Brewer, 1979). Accordingly, we extend our theorizing by identifying impression management attribution (i.e., employees' cognitive judgment that a leader's SNS self-disclosure is strategically motivated to shape others' impressions) as the boundary condition that moderates the relationship between leaders' disclosures on SNSs and dispositional inferences. We choose impression management attribution as the moderator because it directly represents the type of boundary condition described by the discounting principle in theories of dispositional attribution (Reeder & Brewer, 1979), and because the public and curated nature of SNS self-disclosure makes employees' skepticism about leaders' motives particularly salient in this context (Bazarova & Choi, 2014).

Our research makes several contributions to the leadership and self-disclosure literatures. First, by examining leaders' self-disclosure on SNSs and its association with employee followership behavior, we extend self-disclosure theory beyond traditional offline contexts and into the increasingly consequential domain of digital leader-follower interactions. Second, by distinguishing between work-related and non-work-related self-disclosures and identifying their differential associations with agentic and communal characteristic perceptions, respectively, we advance a more nuanced, content-specific understanding of how leaders' online disclosures are linked to follower responses. Third, by incorporating impression management attribution as a boundary condition, we apply the discounting principle of attribution theory to show that the informational value of leaders' online disclosures for dispositional inference is contingent upon followers' assessments of the underlying motives. Finally, by grounding our theoretical model in dispositional attribution theories, we bridge the gap between offline attribution research and the study of online organizational behavior, offering a theoretically integrated account of how and when leaders' digital self-presentation is associated with employee followership behavior.

Theoretical background and research hypotheses

Theories of dispositional attribution

Theories of dispositional attribution suggest that people interpret the behaviors they witness as clues to infer the characteristics of others (Green & Mitchell, 1979; Jones & Davis, 1965). Particularly, observers are inclined to

attribute behaviors to personal characteristics, as this cognitive shortcut is simpler than meticulously considering the various external factors that might influence those behaviors (Park et al., 2022). Dispositional attribution theories encompass two fundamental principles. The first, known as the correspondence principle, suggests that when an actor's observed behavior aligns with the characteristics associated with a behavioral prototype, the observer is likely to classify the actor as possessing those corresponding characteristics (Jones & Davis, 1965). For example, when managers detect elevated instances of voice behavior among their employees, they are inclined to infer that the employees possess proactivity—a characteristic with which voice behavior is prototypically associated (Park et al., 2022).

In addition to the correspondence principle, theories of dispositional attribution also propose the discounting principle, which limits the extent to which observers draw inferences about an individual's characteristics (Ross, 1977; Trope, 1986). The discounting principle suggests that observers are less likely to infer an actor's inherent characteristics from a behavior when they perceive plausible non-dispositional reasons for that behavior (Reeder & Brewer, 1979). The correspondence and discounting principle are considered inseparable pillars of dispositional inferences, as they guide observers in their natural tendency to seek the causes of an actor's behavior in two primary sources: the actor's internal traits and the boundary conditions (Gilbert, 1998; Kelley, 1973). The correspondence principle facilitates the identification of internal causes, attributing behaviors to the actor's inherent characteristics, while the discounting principle accounts for the potential impact of boundary conditions, moderating the attribution accordingly.

Leader self-disclosure on SNSs and employee followership behavior

Following the correspondence principle of the dispositional attribution theories (Jones & Davis, 1965), we suggest that employees may attribute the characteristics of leaders' self-disclosures on SNSs, and the leaders who display work-related self-disclosures on SNSs are classified as having the agentic characteristics; in comparison, the leaders who display non-work-related self-disclosures on SNSs are classified as having the communal characteristics. Drawing upon the fundamental dimensions of social cognition and the agency-communion framework (Abele & Wojciszke, 2014; Fiske et al., 2007), individuals primarily evaluate others along two axes: agency and communion. In the leadership domain, followers routinely evaluate leaders along both agentic and communal dimensions, and these evaluations carry important implications for follower attitudes and behaviors (Epitropaki & Martin, 2004).

Specifically, leaders' work-related self-disclosures on SNSs encompass sharing information about their work activities and experiences, including work instructions, future plans, significant official matters, and organizational rules or policies (James et al., 2015; Osatuyi et al., 2018). These disclosures aid employees in accomplishing their official duties, understanding company policies, clarifying performance expectations, and being apprised of the procedures for fulfilling their professional responsibilities (Nifadkar et al., 2019). Consequently, employees are likely to perceive their leaders as competent and trustworthy, as work-related content on SNSs inherently signals professional capability, ambition, and task dedication. According to the correspondence principle, such disclosures systematically elicit dispositional inferences aligned with agentic characteristics. This inferential process is further supported by the social identity theory of leadership (Hogg, 2001) and identity signaling research (Fauchart & Gruber, 2011), which suggest that work-related disclosures act as salient behavioral signals that align with task-oriented leader prototypes. By publicly embodying these competence-based prototypes, leaders may reinforce employees' attributions of their agentic qualities.

Similarly, leaders' non-work-related self-disclosures on SNSs are likely to be associated with employees' perceptions of communal characteristics. These disclosures involve sharing highly discretionary information about personal activities, thoughts, or life experiences, such as family plans (Nifadkar et al., 2019). Because leaders possess considerable autonomy in determining the extent of personal details they reveal, sharing this information via SNSs fosters a sense of familiarity and relational closeness between employees and leaders (Ollier-Malaterre & Foucreault, 2021; Yang et al., 2023; Zheng & Davison, 2022). Prior research corroborates that disclosing personal information online is associated with increased liking, closeness (Sprecher et al., 2013), and perceived warmth (Rothbard et al., 2022). Thus, observing leaders' non-work-related disclosures on SNSs leads employees to perceive them as embodying warmth, amiability, and cooperativeness—the core elements of communal characteristics. Further supporting this inferential process, social identity perspectives (Fauchart & Gruber, 2011; Hogg, 2001) suggest that personal disclosures serve as relational cues aligning with communal leader prototypes. By publicly signaling a valuation of interpersonal bonds and empathy, leaders may reinforce employees' corresponding attributions of their communal characteristics.

Taken together, work-related disclosures provide information primarily about the leader's task competence and professional orientation, making agentic inferences the most direct and natural attribution. Although such disclosures

might carry secondary communal implications (e.g., signaling commitment to a shared organizational mission), these inferences are distal and require additional inferential steps. The social identity framework further supports this reasoning: task-domain signals most readily activate competence-based (agentic) categorizations rather than warmth-based (communal) ones (Fauchart & Gruber, 2011; Hogg, 2001). The converse logic applies to non-work-related disclosures, which provide information relevant to the relational domain and thus most directly activate communal rather than agentic inferences. Accordingly, we propose:

Hypothesis 1 Leader work-related self-disclosures on SNSs are positively related to perceptions of leader agentic characteristics.

Hypothesis 2 Leader non-work-related self-disclosures on SNSs are positively related to perceptions of leader communal characteristics.

We propose that both agentic and communal characteristics positively predict employee followership behavior, which involves an employee's active participation in organizational goals through the acceptance of a leader's influence (Wang et al., 2022). Agentic and communal characteristics represent the core task and relational roles central to prototypical leadership schemas (Epitropaki & Martin, 2004; Lord et al., 2017) and serve as critical predictors of overall leader effectiveness (Zapata & Hayes-Jones, 2019). Regarding agentic characteristics, their foundation in exerting influence and driving task accomplishment makes them inherently relevant to followership (Koenig et al., 2011). When employees perceive leaders as capable of facilitating task completion and career advancement, they develop heightened commitment and are more inclined to proactively support and follow those leaders (Cui et al., 2024). Additionally, communal characteristics such as warmth and cooperativeness foster interpersonal trust and relational closeness (Casciaro et al., 2014; Chua et al., 2008). Therefore, leaders with communal characteristics are likely to improve employees' followership behavior. Notably, although these communal attributions often stem from non-work-related disclosures, the resulting positive impressions are not confined to the personal domain. Employees who perceive their leader as warm and trustworthy form a generalized favorable impression that carries over into the work context, thereby increasing their willingness to engage in followership behaviors. This spillover effect aligns with leader-member exchange research, which demonstrates that relational trust cultivated through interpersonal interactions strongly predicts followers' subsequent work-related behaviors (Graen & Uhl-Bien, 1995). Taken together, we propose:

Hypothesis 3 Agentic and communal characteristics are positively related to employee followership behavior.

Integrating Hypotheses 1, 2, and 3, and applying the logic of mediation effects, we propose the following hypotheses:

Hypothesis 4 Leader work-related self-disclosures on SNSs have a positive indirect effect on employee followership behavior through agentic characteristics.

Hypothesis 5 Leader non-work-related self-disclosures on SNSs have a positive indirect effect on employee followership behavior through communal characteristics.

The moderating role of impression management attribution

According to the discounting principle of dispositional attribution theories (Kelley, 1973; Reeder & Brewer, 1979), when an individual identifies plausible non-dispositional reasons for an observed behavior, the likelihood of attributing that behavior to the actor's dispositions may significantly reduce. In our model, impression management attribution (i.e., an observer's cognitive judgment that a leader's online disclosures are strategically motivated to cultivate a favorable public image rather than being a spontaneous expression [Bharanitharan et al., 2021; Bolino et al., 2008]) functions as exactly such a boundary condition that may reduce the extent to which leader self-disclosure on SNSs is viewed as diagnostic of their characteristics. SNS platforms provide users with extensive control over their self-presentation, allowing them to selectively edit and refine information to craft an optimal self-image (Fox & Vendemia, 2016; Michikyan et al., 2014). Consequently, compared with offline interactions, information presented on SNSs is often perceived as inherently more strategic (Michikyan et al., 2014). When employees attribute a leader's self-disclosure on SNSs to impression management motives, they perceive the behavior as a calculated maneuver rather than an organic reflection of the leader's actual qualities (Bareket-Bojmel et al., 2016). This skepticism regarding the underlying strategic intent attenuates the informational value of the disclosure, thereby weakening the positive relationship between leaders' self-disclosures on SNSs and employees' perceptions of their inherent characteristics.

Specifically, employees who exhibit high levels of impression management attribution are more likely to view their leader's work-related disclosures, such as posts about professional achievements or career reflections—as deliberate self-promotion. This skepticism reduces the informativeness of such disclosures for agentic characteristic inferences, thereby attenuating the positive relationship

between work-related self-disclosure and perceived agentic characteristics. Following the logic of moderated mediation (Edwards & Lambert, 2007), because the first-stage path from work-related self-disclosure to agentic characteristics is weakened by impression management attribution, the downstream indirect effect on followership behavior via agentic characteristics will be correspondingly diminished. Thus, we propose:

Hypothesis 6 Impression management attribution moderates the positive relationship between a leader's work-related self-disclosures on SNSs and agentic characteristics, such that this relationship is weaker when impression management attribution is high. Consequently, the indirect effect of work-related self-disclosures on employee followership behavior through agentic characteristics is also weaker when impression management attribution is high.

Similarly, for non-work-related disclosures on SNSs (e.g., posts about family activities or personal hobbies), employees with high impression management attribution may view these disclosures as calculated attempts to appear relatable or likable rather than genuine cues of interpersonal warmth (Bolino et al., 2008). This perception of strategic intent diminishes the degree to which non-work-related disclosures on SNSs serve as informative cues for communal characteristic inferences. Accordingly, the first-stage relationship between non-work-related self-disclosure on SNSs and perceived communal characteristics is weakened, which in turn diminishes the downstream indirect effect on followership behavior. Therefore, we propose:

Hypothesis 7 Impression management attribution moderates the positive relationship between a leader's non-work-related self-disclosures on SNSs and communal characteristics, such that this relationship is weaker when impression management attribution is high. Consequently, the indirect effect of non-work-related self-disclosures on employee followership behavior through communal characteristics is also weaker when impression management attribution is high.

Methods

Design and participants

We used the G*Power 3.1 to determine the required sample size with the effect size specified as $f^2 = 0.25$, $\alpha = 0.05$, and power = 0.95. The results indicated a minimum required sample size of approximately 108 participants. Because our study used a time-lagged design and involved potential attrition and invalid responses, we recruited a larger initial sample from the eligible employee pool available through cooperating organizations. Accordingly, we recruited 400 full-time employees to participate in our study, who were from various organizations located in the southern and southwestern of China. Their professional backgrounds spanned a spectrum of industries, with the following representation: technology (7.1%), service (12.1%), manufacturing (23.5%), education (10.3%), finance (13.5%), and other sectors (33.5%)[1]. We contacted the human resource departments of cooperating organizations across multiple industries and invited their employees to participate on a voluntary and anonymous basis. Questionnaires were distributed to employees during working hours. To ensure that participants responded in the capacity of followers rather than leaders, the HR departments assisted in directing the questionnaire to non-managerial and lower-level employees. The questionnaire also collected each participant's position level (1 = employee, 2 = low-level manager, 3 = middle-level manager, 4 = top-level manager). Moreover, a rigorous screening process was implemented to ensure the effectiveness of the survey. The screening procedure consisted of a single-choice question at the beginning of the questionnaire, asking respondents whether they had an account on any SNSs, such as Weibo, WeChat, QQ, Facebook, or Twitter, and whether they regularly browsed their leaders' SNS content. Respondents who answered negatively to either part of this question were directed to the end of the survey and excluded from the study. This screening criterion ensured that all participants in the final sample had direct and regular exposure to their leaders' self-disclosures on SNSs. Before the survey begins, we instructed the participants some detailed information about the survey (e.g., this is a two-wave survey), and they can participate in or withdraw from the survey at any time voluntarily, and their answers will be kept completely confidential.

The survey was conducted in two phases with a one-month interval. At Time 1, participants completed measures of leaders' work-related self-disclosure on SNSs, leaders' non-work-related self-disclosure on SNSs, impression management attribution, and reported their demographic information. In this phase, a total of 377 questionnaires were collected. Among these, 9 participants were excluded based on the screening

[1] Although participants were drawn from multiple industries, the study was conducted at the individual employee level and was not designed as a nested or multilevel sampling design. Participants were not recruited as intact teams or organizations, were not asked to evaluate the same leader, and no company, team, or leader level identifiers were collected. Thus, leader level, team level, or organization level nesting was not built into the design. We conducted an additional robustness check by including industry dummy variables in the analyses. The pattern of results remained substantively unchanged, and all hypothesized relationships retained the same direction and significance.

criterion because they either did not have an SNS account or did not regularly browse their leaders' SNS content. One month later (Time 2), we invited the remaining 368 participants completed measures of agentic characteristics, communal characteristics, and followership behavior. A total of 290 questionnaires were collected. After sorting out the questionnaire data, we excluded responses that were incomplete or exhibited patterns of uniformity (e.g., a participant selected the identical response option for all items across an entire scale or across multiple consecutive scales) or random completion (e.g., a participant contained clearly contradictory answers to semantically related items within the same scale or if the completion time fell below one-third of the median completion time for the full sample). The final sample consisted of 281 employees, with a response rate of 70.25%. Within the sample, 54.4% of participants were males, with an average age of 34.02 years (SD=9.49); 72.6% had a bachelor's degree or above; 83.6% had worked for more than 2 years; 75.4% worked in nonsupervisory positions. The remaining participants held low-level or middle-level managerial titles but were not the leaders being evaluated; all participants reported on the SNS disclosure behaviors of their own immediate supervisors. We also conducted a sensitivity power analysis using G*Power 3.1 based on the final sample size. The results revealed that the final sample of 281 participants was sufficient to detect an effect as small as $f^2 = 0.089$ with 95% power at $\alpha=0.050$, suggesting that the final sample had adequate sensitivity to detect effects smaller than the effect size specified in the a priori power analysis.

This study was pre-registered, and the data and syntax used in this study can be accessed via the following link: https://osf.io/yz82w/overview?view_only=cabaa7b036804840ad38d4c20947faf3.

Measures

We used a translation/back-translation procedure (Brislin, 1980) to translate all the English-based measures into Chinese. Unless otherwise noted, all items were rated on a 5-point Likert scale ranging from 1 (strongly disagree) to 5 (strongly agree). We formed mean scores for all reported measures by averaging the items within each scale, with higher scores indicating higher levels of the corresponding construct.

Work-related self-disclosure on SNSs

Six items used to assess leader's work-related self-disclosure on SNSs were adapted from the Nifadkar et al. (2019) work-related information sharing scale. Participants were instructed to evaluate the frequency and content of their direct leaders' work-related self-disclosure behaviors on SNSs based on their regular observations. Sample items were "My leader shares work instructions on SNSs" and "My leader shares his/her future work plan on SNSs" ($\alpha=0.953$).

Non-work-related self-disclosure on SNSs

Six items used to assess leader's non-work-related self-disclosure on SNSs were adapted from the Nifadkar et al. (2019) non-work-related information sharing scale. Participants were instructed to evaluate the frequency and content of their direct leaders' non-work-related self-disclosure behaviors on SNSs based on their regular observations. Sample items include "My leader shares important changes in his/her family life on SNSs" and "My leader shares how he/she deals with his/her family-related issues on SNSs" ($\alpha=0.961$).

Agentic characteristics

We measure agentic characteristics with a 5-item scale developed by Zapata and Hayes-Jones (2019). Participants were asked to rate the extent to which they perceived their leaders as possessing agentic characteristic. A sample item was "My leader is skillful" ($\alpha=0.937$).

Communal characteristics

Communal characteristics were measured using the 5-item scale developed by Zapata and Hayes-Jones (2019). Participants were asked to rate the extent to which they perceived their leaders as possessing communal characteristic. A sample item was "My leader is warm" ($\alpha=0.938$).

Impression management attribution

Impression management attribution was assessed using the 4-item scale used by Bharanitharan et al. (2021). Participants were asked to rate the extent to which they believed their leaders' SNS disclosures were motivated by impression management purposes. A sample item was "My leader conducts work/non-work-related self-disclosure on SNSs because it will look good to his/her followers" ($\alpha=0.938$).

Followership behavior[2]

We assessed followership behavior with a 6-item scale developed by Wang et al. (2022). Participants were asked

[2] We retained the term followership behavior because it is the label commonly used in the literature and in the original scale. In the present study, however, the construct was measured through employees' self-reports and should therefore be interpreted as self-reported followership behavior rather than objectively observed behavior

to report the extent to which they engaged in various followership behaviors toward their leaders. A sample item was "I will do my best to assist the leader in his/her work" (α = 0.950).

Control variables

Consistent with previous studies, we controlled for the participants' gender, age, education, tenure, and position, as these variables affect our outcome variables, such as employees' response to self-disclosure on SNSs and the evaluation of the characteristics of the discloser (Gibson et al., 2018; Osatuyi et al., 2018; Rosette & Tost, 2010; Utz, 2015; Wang et al., 2022).

Data analysis

First, we used SPSS 22.0 to assess the internal consistency reliability of each scale by calculating Cronbach's alpha coefficients. At the same time, we used SPSS 22.0 to conduct preliminary analysis (i.e., mean, standard deviation, and correlations of the variables). Then, we conducted a confirmatory factor analysis using MPLUS 7.40. In the next step, we performed path analysis using MPLUS 7.40 to test our hypotheses. To reduce the risk of multicollinearity, the interaction variables were mean-centered. Finally, to examine the indirect and moderated mediation effects, we applied bootstrapping procedures with 5,000 replications to estimate the 95% confidence intervals (CIs; Edwards & Lambert, 2007) of the indirect effect and evaluated the differences between the indirect effects in both high and low levels of impression management attribution.

Results

Confirmatory factor analyses

The confirmatory factor analysis (CFA) results are shown in Table 1. The proposed six-factor model ($\chi^2 = 1052.567$, $df = 449$, CFI = 0.938, TLI = 0.932, RMSEA = 0.069, SRMR = 0.041)) fits the data better than that of the other models, indicating that the core variables in our study have good discrimination validity.

Moreover, we followed the approach recommended by Fornell and Larcker (1981) to further assess the discriminant validity. According to the Fornell-Larcker criterion, discriminant validity is supported when the average variance extracted (AVE) is greater than maximum shared variance (MSV). As reported in supplemental materials Table S1, the AVE values for all focal constructs exceeded the commonly recommended threshold of 0.500 and were greater than their corresponding MSV values. Therefore, the six factors demonstrated discriminant validity.

Common method variance

Table 1 Results of confirmatory factor analysis

Model	χ^2	df	χ^2/df	CFI	TLI	SRMR	RMSEA
Six-factor model	1052.567	449	2.344	0.938	0.932	0.041	0.069
Five-factor model	2422.532	454	5.336	0.799	0.780	0.163	0.124
Four-factor model	3606.630	458	7.875	0.679	0.652	0.204	0.156
Three-factor model	5163.956	461	11.201	0.520	0.483	0.235	0.191
Two-factor model	6134.802	463	13.250	0.421	0.380	0.235	0.209
One-factor model	6961.629	464	15.004	0.337	0.291	0.241	0.223

Notes.N = 281

Six-factor model: Work-related self-disclosure on SNSs; Non-work-related self-disclosure on SNSs; Impression management attribution; Agentic characteristics; Communal characteristics; Followership behavior

Five-factor model: Work-related self-disclosure on SNSs + Agentic characteristics; Non-work-related self-disclosure on SNSs; Impression management attribution; Communal characteristics; Followership behavior

Four-factor model: Work-related self-disclosure on SNSs + Agentic characteristics; Non-work-related self-disclosure on SNSs + Communal characteristics; Impression management attribution; Followership behavior

Three-factor model: Work-related self-disclosure on SNSs + Agentic characteristics + Followership behavior; Non-work-related self-disclosure on SNSs + Communal characteristics; Impression management attribution

Two-factor model: Work-related self-disclosure on SNSs + Agentic characteristics + Non-work-related self-disclosure on SNSs + Communal characteristics + Followership behavior; Impression management attribution;

One-factor model: Work-related self-disclosure on SNSs + Agentic characteristics + Non-work-related self-disclosure on SNSs + Communal characteristics + Impression management attribution + Followership behavior

We applied Harman's single-factor test to check for CMV (Podsakoff et al., 2003). The results showed that the unrotated factor solution revealed that factors with eigenvalues

above 1 accounted for 80.293% of the total variance. Importantly, the first principal component explained only 36.301% of the variance, which is less than half of the total variance explained. These results indicated that CMV in this study was effectively controlled. In addition, according to Kock (2015), a model is considered free of common method bias if all inner-model variance inflation factors (VIFs) are 3.3 or lower. In our analysis, all VIFs ranged from 1.011 to 2.176, all falling within the acceptable limit. Therefore, CMV remains within a tolerable range.

Descriptive statistics and correlations

Means, standard deviations, correlations of study variables, and Cronbach's alpha coefficients are presented in Table 2.

Hypotheses testing

Table 3 and Fig. 1 present the results of the path analysis. As shown in Table 3, work-related self-disclosures on SNSs were positively related to agentic characteristics ($b = 0.265$, $p < .001$), supporting Hypothesis 1. Moreover, non-work-related self-disclosures on SNSs were positively related to communal characteristics ($b = 0.233$, $p < .001$), supporting Hypothesis 2. Furthermore, both agentic characteristics ($b = 0.276$, $p = .003$) and communal characteristics ($b = 0.213$, $p = .020$) were positively related to employee followership behavior. Therefore, Hypothesis 3 was supported.

The results also showed that the interaction term of impression management attribution and work-related self-disclosures on SNSs in predicting agentic characteristics was significant ($b = -0.225$, $p < .001$). We further conducted a simple slope test to verify the moderating effect of impression management attribution on the relationship between work-related self-disclosures on SNS and agentic characteristics. As presented in Fig. 2, simple slope analysis revealed that the relationship between work-related self-disclosures on SNSs and agentic characteristics was not significant among employees with high levels of impression management attribution ($b = 0.062$, $p = .243$, 95% CI = [-0.059, 0.156]), but was significant among those with low levels of impression management attribution ($b = 0.469$, $p < .001$, 95% CI = [0.239, 0.562]). The difference between the two conditions was also significant (difference = -0.406, $p < .001$, 95% CI = [-0.544, -0.232]). Therefore, Hypothesis 6 was initially supported.

Additionally, the interaction term of impression management attribution and non-work-related self-disclosures on SNSs in predicting communal characteristics was significant ($b = -0.233$, $p < .001$). As presented in Fig. 3, simple slope analysis revealed that the relationship between non-work-related self-disclosures on SNSs and communal characteristics was not significant among employees with high levels of impression management attribution ($b = 0.022$, $p = .687$, 95% CI = [-0.100, 0.117]), but was significant among those with low levels of impression management attribution ($b = 0.443$, $p < .001$, 95% CI = [0.303, 0.537]). The difference between the two conditions was also significant

Table 2 Descriptive statistics and correlations results

Variables	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11
1. Gender (T1)	-										
2. Age (T1)	-0.066	-									
3. Education (T1)	-0.007	0.450**	-								
4. Tenure (T1)	-0.071	0.785**	-0.400**	-							
5. Position (T1)	-0.177**	0.277**	0.040	0.342**	-						
6. Work-related self-disclosure on SNSs (T1)	0.027	0.045	-0.157**	0.069	0.008	**(0.953)**					
7. Non-work-related self-disclosure on SNSs (T1)	0.060	0.015	-0.077	0.009	-0.001	0.690**	**(0.961)**				
8. Impression management attribution (T1)	0.065	-0.047	0.012	-0.052	-0.067	0.416**	0.360**	**(0.938)**			
9. Agentic characteristics (T2)	-0.027	0.006	0.012	-0.017	-0.038	0.355**	0.121*	0.276**	**(0.937)**		
10. Communal characteristics (T2)	0.001	-0.035	0.084	-0.069	-0.025	0.165**	0.249**	0.213**	0.735**	**(0.938)**	
11. Followership behavior (T2)	-0.052	0.106	-0.063	0.093	-0.021	0.140*	0.140*	0.140*	0.455**	0.453**	**(0.950)**
Mean	1.46	34.02	2.86	3.36	1.33	2.71	2.76	2.97	3,66	3.71	3.89
SD	0.50	9.49	0.84	1.56	0.64	0.96	0.95	0.91	0.81	0.75	0.72

Notes.N=281. For gender, 1=male, 2=female. For education, 1=high school or below, 2=junior college, 3=bachelor degree, 4=master's degree or above. For tenure, 1=less than 2 year, 2=2–4 years, 3=5–7 years, 4=8–10 years, 5=more than 10 years. For position, 1=employee, 2=low-level manager, 3=middle-level manager, 4=top-level manager. T1/2=Time 1/2. SD=standard deviation

Cronbach's alpha coefficients are reported on the diagonal in parentheses

*$p < .05$. **$p < .01$

Table 3 Path analysis results of the relationship among leader self-disclosure on SNSs and outcomes (full model)

Variables	Agentic characteristics		Communal characteristics		Followership behavior	
	b	SE	b	SE	b	SE
Gender	-0.056	0.092	-0.052	0.090	-0.070	0.075
Age	0.011	0.008	0.008	0.008	0.003	0.006
Education	0.090	0.062	0.091	0.058	-0.032	0.048
Tenure	-0.040	0.049	-0.039	0.050	0.039	0.040
Position	-0.039	0.078	-0.005	0.081	-0.056	0.071
Work-related self-disclosure on SNSs	0.265***	0.041			-0.073	0.060
Non-work-related self-disclosure on SNSs			0.233***	0.041	0.086	0.062
Impression management attribution	0.156*	0.063	0.147*	0.058		
Work-related self-disclosure on SNSs × Impression management attribution	-0.225***	0.043				
Non-work-related self-disclosure on SNSs × Impression management attribution			-0.233***	0.043		
Agentic characteristics					0.276**	0.093
Communal characteristics					0.213*	0.092

Note. $N = 281$. Unstandardized regression coefficients are reported. Coefficients presented in this Table were estimated simultaneously in one path model

$^{*}p < .05$. $^{**}p < .01$. $^{***}p < .001$

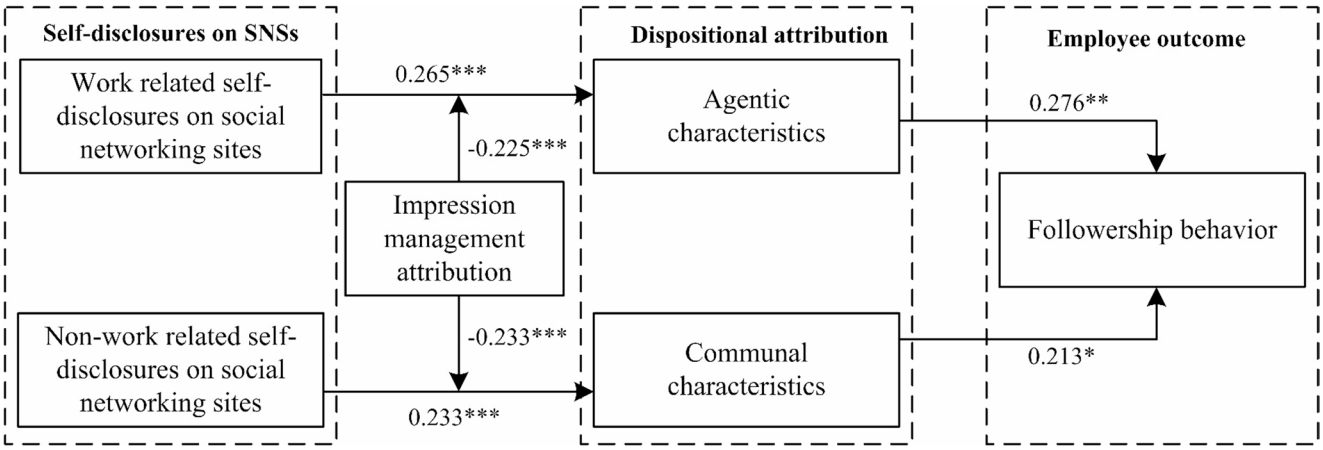


Fig. 1 Path Analysis Results Notes. Unstandardized Regression Coefficients are reported. *p < .05; ** p < .01, *** p < .001



Fig. 2 The Moderating Role of Impression Management Attribution on Relationship Between Work-Related Self-Disclosure on SNSs and Agentic Characteristics

(difference = -0.421, $p < .001$, 95% CI = [-0.568, -0.257]). Hence, Hypothesis 7 was initially supported.

We conducted bias-corrected bootstrapping with 5,000 replications to test the mediated and moderated, and moderated mediation hypotheses (see Table 4)[3]. The results indicated that work-related self-disclosures on SNSs were positively related to followership behavior via agentic characteristics (indirect effect = 0.073, $p = .005$, 95% CI =

[3] To examine the specificity of the proposed mediation pathways, we estimated a full model that included all four possible indirect effects by adding two cross-paths (work-related self-disclosure on SNSs → communal characteristics and non-work-related self-disclosure on SNSs → agentic characteristics) to the hypothesized model. The results showed that neither cross-path was significant (work-related self-disclosure on SNSs → communal characteristics: Estimate = 0.040, $p = .579$; non-work-related self-disclosure on SNSs → agentic characteristics: Estimate = -0.129, $p = .106$), and neither cross-path indirect effect was significant. The two hypothesized indirect effects remained significant in this full model.

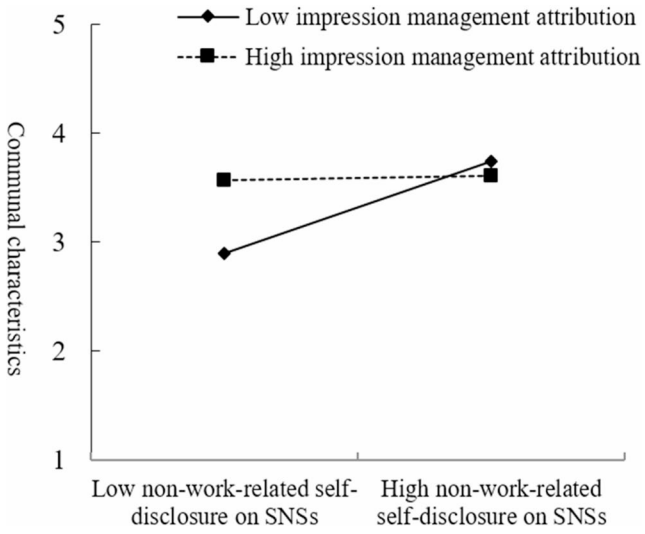


Fig. 3 The Moderating Role of Impression Management Attribution on Relationship Between Non-Work-Related Self-Disclosure on SNSs and Communal Characteristics

[0.031, 0.137]). Thus, Hypothesis 4 was supported. Moreover, non-work-related self-disclosures on SNSs were positively related to followership behavior through communal characteristics (indirect effect = 0.050, p = .028, 95% CI = [0.011, 0.103]), supporting Hypothesis 5.

The conditional indirect effects showed that the indirect effect of work-related self-disclosures on SNSs on followership behavior through agentic characteristics was not significant when impression management attribution was high (estimate = 0.017, p = .308, 95% CI = [-0.009, 0.060]). However, the indirect effect of work-related self-disclosures on SNSs on followership behavior through agentic characteristics was significant when impression management attribution was low (estimate = 0.130, p = .003, 95% CI = [0.054, 0.227]). The difference between these indirect effects was also significant (estimate = -0.112, p = .005, 95% CI = [-0.205, -0.045]). Thus, Hypothesis 6 was supported. In addition, the results indicated that the indirect effect of non-work-related self-disclosures on SNSs on followership behavior via communal characteristics was not significant when impression management attribution was high (estimate = 0.005, p = .717, 95% CI = [-0.019, 0.035]), and the indirect effect was significant when impression management attribution was low (estimate = 0.095, p = .023, 95% CI = [0.018, 0.185]). The difference between these indirect effects was also significant (estimate = -0.090, p = .033, 95% CI = [-0.183, -0.018]). Consequently, Hypothesis 7 was supported.

Table 4 Results of moderated mediation analysis (full model)

Paths & effects	Estimate	Bootstrapping 95% CI	
		LL	UL
Indirect effect (Hypotheses 4 & 5)			
Work-related self-disclosure on SNSs →Agentic characteristics →Followership behavior	0.073	0.031	0.137
Non-work-related self-disclosure on SNSs →Communal characteristics →Followership behavior	0.050	0.011	0.103
Conditional effects (Hypotheses 6 & 7)			
Work-related self-disclosure on SNSs →Agentic characteristics			
High impression management attribution (+1 SD)	0.062	-0.059	0.156
Low impression management attribution (-1 SD)	0.469	0.329	0.562
Difference	-0.406	-0.544	-0.232
Non-work-related self-disclosure on SNSs →Communal characteristics			
High impression management attribution (+1 SD)	0.022	-0.100	0.117
Low impression management attribution (-1 SD)	0.443	0.303	0.537
Difference	-0.421	-0.568	-0.257
Conditional indirect effects (Hypotheses 8 & 9)			
Work-related self-disclosure on SNSs →Agentic characteristics →Followership behavior			
High impression management attribution (+1 SD)	0.017	-0.009	0.060
Low impression management attribution (-1 SD)	0.130	0.054	0.227
Difference	-0.112	-0.205	-0.045
Non-work-related self-disclosure on SNSs →Communal characteristics →Followership behavior			
High impression management attribution (+1 SD)	0.005	-0.019	0.035
Low impression management attribution (-1 SD)	0.095	0.018	0.185
Difference	-0.090	-0.183	-0.018

Note. N = 281. CI = confidence intervals; LL = lower limit; UL = upper limit. Bootstrap = 5,000 times

General discussion

Overall, our results indicate that work-related self-disclosure on SNSs is positively associated with perceptions of agentic characteristics, whereas non-work-related self-disclosure is positively associated with perceptions of communal characteristics. This dual-pathway pattern is consistent

with the agency-communion framework in social cognition research (Abele & Wojciszke, 2014; Fiske et al., 2007), suggesting that followers utilize specific online behavioral cues to form distinct dispositional judgments about leaders. Furthermore, the significant mediating roles of these characteristics extend prior work (e.g., Rothbard et al., 2022) by shifting the scholarly focus from whether leader self-disclosure matters to how different types of disclosure may be linked to specific psychological evaluations. This pattern also resonates with findings in offline leadership contexts, where the nature of disclosed information is closely tied to followers' perceptions of leader qualities (Shamir & Eilam, 2005).

Moreover, our findings challenge the implicit assumption in some prior literature that leader self-disclosure universally and unconditionally yields positive relational outcomes. By identifying impression management attribution as a critical boundary condition, our results provide empirical support for the discounting principle of attribution theory (Kelley, 1973; Reeder & Brewer, 1979). When followers attributed leaders' SNS disclosures to strategic impression management motives, the positive associations between self-disclosure and characteristic perceptions were significantly attenuated. In other words, even when the content of a leader's disclosure is factually accurate, followers' skepticism regarding the self-promotional intent behind the act of disclosing is sufficient to trigger a discounting effect on dispositional inferences. This nuanced interpretation suggests that the relationship between leaders' online disclosures and follower perceptions depends not only on the informational content but also on how followers infer the underlying motives.

Theoretical contributions

First, this study enriches self-disclosure theory by examining leaders' self-disclosures on SNSs and its relationship with employee followership behavior. Although previous studies have explored how leaders' general self-disclosure affect employees' attitudes and behaviors (e.g., Ito et al., 2025; Nifadkar et al., 2019), and related work has begun to examine boundary blurring through online disclosure in organizational settings (Rothbard et al., 2022), the domain of leaders' online self-disclosure and its implications for follower responses remains largely underexplored. Our study contributes by providing initial evidence that leaders' self-disclosure on SNSs is associated with employee followership behavior, thereby extending self-disclosure theory into the digital leadership context. It also lays the foundation for future research on the relationship between online interaction, trait perception, and offline behaviors.

Second, this study advances self-disclosure theory by distinguishing two types of leaders' self-disclosures on SNSs, namely work-related and non-work-related self-disclosures, and revealing that these two types produce are associated with employee followership behavior through different mediating processes. Our results revealed that leaders' work-related self-disclosure on SNSs was positively associated with perceptions of agentic characteristics, whereas non-work-related self-disclosure was positively associated with perceptions of communal characteristics, which in turn were positively related to followership behavior. These findings are consistent with the agency-communion framework (Abele & Wojciszke, 2014; Fiske et al., 2007), which posits that agency and communion constitute two fundamental dimensions of social judgment. Moreover, from the perspective of the social identity theory of leadership (Hogg, 2001), leaders who share work-related content may reinforce their role-based prototypicality, activating agentic perceptions, while those who share non-work-related content may signal relational orientation, activating communal perceptions. Our findings provided empirical support for this theoretically grounded distinction, thus contributing to self-disclosure theory.

Third, this study contributes to the understanding of when leaders' self-disclosures on SNSs is associated with employees' characteristic inferences by identifying impression management attribution as a boundary condition. In the process of evaluating others, individuals often utilize accessible social information present within online environments (Westerman et al., 2015), and the content disclosed on SNSs constitutes one type of such information. Our results showed that when employees attributed leaders' online self-disclosures to impression management motives, the positive associations between self-disclosure and characteristic perceptions were attenuated. This finding provided empirical support for the discounting principle of attribution theory (Kelley, 1973) in the context of digital leader-follower interactions. In doing so, our study not only contributes to the extant literature on leaders' self-disclosure on SNSs but also offers practical insights for leaders aiming to enhance their leadership effectiveness.

Finally, this study contributes to research on dispositional attribution theories by extending them to the context of leader behavior on SNSs. Although prior research has applied this theoretical perspective to offline employee behavior (Park et al., 2022), less is known about how observers draw dispositional inferences from work-related interactions in online contexts. Our study applies dispositional attribution theories to examine how employees infer leaders' agentic and communal characteristics from leaders' self-disclosures on SNSs and when these inferences are weakened by employees' impression management attribution. Specifically, the

correspondence principle explained why leaders' self-disclosures on SNSs was related to perceptions of agentic and communal characteristics. The discounting principle explained when impression management attribution constrained the extent to which employees drew inferences about leaders' characteristics. This not only enriches the understanding of dispositional attribution theories but also provides theoretical support for further exploration of the potential of leaders' online behavior to improve employee outcomes.

Practical implications

Our research provides actionable guidance for organizations and leaders in managing their online presence and interactions on SNSs. First, our findings suggest that the type of information leaders share on SNSs is relevant to how they are perceived by employees. Specifically, work-related self-disclosures were positively associated with perceptions of agentic characteristics, such as competence, assertiveness, and ambition, while non-work-related self-disclosures were positively associated with perceptions of communal characteristics, such as warmth, trustworthiness, and inclusiveness. These findings suggest that leaders may benefit from being mindful of the content they share on SNSs. Rather than using SNSs simply to create a favorable image, leaders may benefit from ensuring that their online disclosures are consistent with their actual work roles, experiences, and interpersonal style.

Second, our findings suggest that employees' impression management attributions qualify the associations between leaders' self-disclosures on SNSs and employees' perceptions of leader characteristics. The observed moderating effect indicates that when employees perceive leaders' self-disclosures as strategically motivated, the positive associations between self-disclosure and characteristic perceptions tend to be weaker. Thus, leaders may benefit from being attentive not only to the content of their online disclosures but also to how such disclosures may be interpreted by employees. In particular, disclosures that are consistent with leaders' actual experiences, values, and offline interactions may be less likely to be viewed as strategic self-presentation. Organizations may also consider developing general guidelines for professional SNS use, helping leaders evaluate the appropriateness, consistency, and audience relevance of their shared content. Such guidelines should emphasize appropriateness and responsible online communication rather than encourage leaders to use SNSs as a tool for impression management.

Third, our findings suggest that leaders' self-disclosures on SNSs is positively associated with employee followership behavior. Given that such disclosures are largely autonomous in nature, organizations may benefit from creating voluntary feedback channels to understand how leaders' online communication is perceived by employees. For example, periodic surveys or confidential feedback forums could provide employees with opportunities to share their views on leaders' SNS activity. Such feedback may help leaders reflect on their online engagement practices and align them more closely with organizational values and employee expectations.

Limitations and future research directions

It is important to acknowledge the limitations inherent in our research, which should be considered and addressed in subsequent research endeavors. First, this research mainly focuses on the positive impacts of leaders' self-disclosure on SNSs. Nevertheless, extant literature has found that self-disclosure in the workplace may lead to disruptive self-disclosure, thus threatening the status of leaders, exposing personal weaknesses, and damaging interpersonal relationships in the workplace (Gibson et al., 2018; Phillips et al., 2009), which implies the possible negative impact of self-disclosure on SNSs. Thus, we encourage subsequent scholarly endeavors to focus on examining the potential adverse consequences of leaders' self-disclosures on SNSs. Such research would contribute to a more comprehensive understanding of the implications of self-disclosures on SNSs.

Second, although we followed prior research in using the term followership behavior (e.g., Organ, 1988; Wang et al., 2022), this construct was measured through employees' self-reports. Self-reported behavioral scales capture employees' perceptions of their own behavioral tendencies or enacted behaviors, but they do not provide the same evidence as objective behavioral records or ratings from other sources. Future research could address this limitation by employing multi-source ratings (e.g., supervisor-rated followership behavior), behavioral observation methods, or objective performance indicators to provide a more directly and robust assessment of followership behavior.

Third, although this study adopted a two-wave time-lagged design, the data remain correlational in nature. The temporal separation between measurement waves helps reduce common method bias and provides evidence of temporal ordering, but it cannot rule out the possibility of reverse causality or the influence of unmeasured third variables (Jam et al., 2017; Nong et al., 2024; Podsakoff et al., 2003). For example, employees who already exhibit high levels of followership behavior may be more attentive to and more positively interpret their leaders' self-disclosures on SNSs. Therefore, causal conclusions should not be drawn from the present findings. Future research would benefit from adopting experimental designs that manipulate

the type and content of leaders' self-disclosures on SNSs, which would allow for stronger causal inferences regarding the proposed relationships.

Fourth, this study focused on impression management attribution as the boundary condition, which exerts an attenuating effect in the same direction on both mediation pathways. Although this is consistent with the general nature of the discounting principle and theoretically well suited for examining act-level motive inferences in the SNS context, this design does not allow us to further differentiate the unique dynamics of the two self-disclosure types. Therefore, future research could explore moderators that may differentially influence the work-related and non-work-related self-disclosure pathways, such as leader traits, team culture, or organizational policies. Moreover, while our study focuses on the attribution of strategic motives under the dispositional attribution framework, related research suggests that broader evaluations of a leader's true self significantly impact follower responses. Thus, future research could enrich our model by integrating the social identity theory of leadership (Hogg, 2001) and exploring how general perceptions of leader authenticity (Guthey & Jackson, 2005; Hahl & Zuckerman, 2014) function as an overarching condition.

Finally, the data for this study were collected from Chinese employees. China is generally characterized as a collectivist society in which hierarchical leader-follower relationships and relational obligations are highly valued (Zhang & Gill, 2019). These cultural features may have implications for the generalizability of the findings (Nong & Mei, 2025). For instance, employees in collectivist cultures may be more attentive to leaders' non-work-related self-disclosure because such behavior signals relational investment, which is consistent with the emphasis on interpersonal harmony. In contrast, in individualist societies where professional and personal boundaries tend to be more clearly delineated, employees may respond differently to leaders' non-work-related disclosures on SNSs. Similarly, the tendency to attribute leaders' self-disclosure to impression management motives may vary across cultural contexts. Future research would benefit from replicating this study in more individualist societies to examine whether the observed associations hold across different cultural settings.

Conclusion

This study examined how leaders' self-disclosure on SNSs is associated with employee followership behavior and the mechanisms and boundary conditions underlying these associations. Using two-wave data from 281 full-time employees, we found that leader's work-related self-disclosure on SNSs was positively associated with followership behavior through perceptions of agentic characteristics, while leader's non-work-related self-disclosure on SNSs was positively associated with followership behavior through perceptions of communal characteristics. Furthermore, impression management attribution attenuated these associations, such that the positive relationships between self-disclosure on SNSs and characteristic perceptions were weaker when employees with high levels of impression management attribution. These findings suggest that what leaders share on SNSs matters for how employees perceive and respond to them, and that the impression management attribution of such disclosures plays an important role in shaping these perceptions. As digital communication continues to permeate organizational life, understanding the implications of leader' online self-disclosure for leader-follower dynamics represents a valuable avenue for both research and practice.

Supplementary Information The online version contains supplementary material available at https://doi.org/10.1007/s12144-026-09601-9.

Author contribution Meilan Nong: Conceptualization, Methodology, Investigation, Data curation, Formal analysis, Writing-original draft Preparation, Writing-review and editing. Wenjuan Mei: Conceptualization, Writing- Original draft preparation, Writing-review and editing, Supervision. All authors have read and agreed to the published version of the manuscript.

Funding This study is supported by the Natural Science Foundation of Anhui Province [2508085QG282].

Data availability The study was pre-registered, and the data and syntax used can be accessed via the following link: https://osf.io/yz82w/overview?view_only=cabaa7b036804840ad38d4c20947faf3.

Declarations

Ethical approval All procedures performed in research involving human participants were according to the institutional and 1964 Helsinki declaration and its subsequent amendments or comparable ethical standards.

Informed consent Informed Consent was obtained from all the participants of this study.

Consent to publish The participants have agreed for their anonymized data to be published.

Conflicts of interest The authors declare that they have no known conflict of interest that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

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